SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #11 · DEBT AND SHAME

“My debt proves I'm irresponsible.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Debt can come from many roads: a job loss, an illness, a divorce, a family emergency, school, rising prices, or simply choices we now regret. But family and culture often attach one meaning to all of them: “You must have been careless.” If a parent was ashamed of owing money, or if people judged us for it, we may carry that verdict even when the facts are more complicated.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is honest about debt. Proverbs says the borrower is slave to the lender, and it also values careful planning. But Scripture never says that owing money defines a person. Paul writes that there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. God knows our frame and is mindful that we are dust, and He has not dealt with us according to our sins. Where we did make poor choices, we can own them, learn, and move forward. Where we did not, we can let go of a verdict that was never ours to carry.

> *“Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus”* (Romans 8:1).

Also see

> “He has not dealt with us according to our sins or repaid us according to our iniquities” (Psalm 103:10).
>
> “For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust” (Psalm 103:14).
>
> “The rich rule over the poor, and the borrower is slave to the lender” (Proverbs 22:7).
>
> “The plans of the diligent bring plenty, as surely as haste leads to poverty” (Proverbs 21:5).

Common self-statements

- Only careless people end up in debt.
- I should have known better.
- Everyone can see I cannot manage money.
- My debt shows what kind of person I am.
- If I were responsible, I would not owe.
- I have failed my family.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself “irresponsible” instead of describing what happened.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing myself as either totally responsible or a total failure with money.
- Personalization: Blaming myself for things that were outside my control, such as illness or layoffs.
- Mental filter: Focusing on the debt and ignoring the ways I have been responsible.

Challenging questions

- How did the debt actually happen, and which parts were choices and which were circumstances?
- What have I done responsibly, such as working, caring for others, or paying on time?

- Would I call a friend in my situation “irresponsible”?
- Where did I learn that debt equals failure?
- What does God say about my worth when I owe?
- What is one wise next step I can take without condemning myself?

Truth summary

> Owing money describes my account, not my character. Some of it may come from my choices and some from things I could not control. Either way, in Christ I am not condemned. I can be honest about the past, take wise steps now, and trust God’s mercy.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Money
- Forgiveness
- Mercy
- Grace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Money/Riches
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Clean — Natalie Grant
God’s cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

East to West — Casting Crowns
God’s forgiveness addresses lingering guilt and fear of condemnation.

Grace Wins — Matthew West
Grace offers a new beginning rather than defining a person by failure.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My debt proves I'm irresponsible"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My debt proves I'm irresponsible." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How did this debt happen?
- ☐ Which parts were choices and which were circumstances?
- ☐ What have I done responsibly?
- ☐ What label am I using on myself?
- ☐ What does God say about me?
- ☐ What is one wise step this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My debt does not define me.
- ☐ There is no condemnation for me in Christ.
- ☐ I can be honest about what happened without attacking myself.
- ☐ Responsible people can still owe.
- ☐ God knows my frame and is mindful that I am dust.
- ☐ I can take one wise step at a time.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ Psalm 103:10
  "He has not dealt with us according to our sins or repaid us according to our iniquities."
- ☐ Psalm 103:14
  "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Facts, not verdicts: Each day, write one fact about your money situation and one thing you did responsibly. Notice whether the harsh label softens.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 8:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "There is no condemnation for me in Christ, so I can face my debt honestly and take one wise step.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Write the story honestly. List how the debt happened. Mark what was a choice, what was circumstance, and what you have learned.
- ☐ Replace the label. Cross out "irresponsible" and write a plain description, such as "I owe $X and I am making a plan."
- ☐ Take one practical step. Make a list of what you owe, or call one creditor, or schedule a visit with a trusted advisor or counselor.
- ☐ Say the verse aloud. Read Romans 8:1 each morning for a week.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My debt proves I'm irresponsible": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A responsible step
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My debt proves I'm irresponsible.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You know how my debt came about. Forgive what I need to be forgiven for, and free me from labels You do not give me. Help me take wise steps and rest in Your mercy. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #12 · DEBT AND SHAME

"I must hide my money problems."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many of us learned that money is private and that trouble should be kept inside the family. Fear of judgment, embarrassment about status, or a parent who always "kept up appearances" can teach us to hide. Hiding can start small, such as not mentioning a bill, and grow into secrecy from a spouse, friends, or church. The cost is isolation and a problem that has no helpers.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says that plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed. We are told to bear one another's burdens and that two are better than one, because if one falls, the other can lift him up. James encourages us to confess to one another and pray for one another. None of this means we must tell everyone everything. It means we should not carry heavy things entirely alone, and that wise, safe people are part of God's help.

> *"Plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed"* (Proverbs 15:22).

Also see

> "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ" (Galatians 6:2).

> "For lack of guidance, a nation falls, but with many counselors comes deliverance" (Proverbs 11:14).

> "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!" (Ecclesiastes 4:9–10).

> "Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail" (James 5:16).

Common self-statements

- If anyone knew, I would be humiliated.
- I have to look like I have everything under control.
- My spouse cannot handle knowing.
- It is better to say nothing.
- I will fix this quietly.
- People would think less of me.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that others will judge or reject me.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know what people would think.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that being found out would be a disaster.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must handle money problems alone.

Challenging questions

- What am I afraid will happen if one safe person knows?
- What has hiding cost me so far, in peace, sleep, and closeness?
- Who has been honest with me about a hard time, and what did I think of them?

- Who is a safe, wise person I could tell first?
- What is the difference between privacy and secrecy?
- What is the smallest honest step I could take this week?

Truth summary

> Privacy can be healthy, but secrecy about a heavy problem keeps me alone with it. God provides counselors, friends, family, and advisers. I can choose a safe person, share honestly, and let help in.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Help
- Friendship
- Wisdom
- Confession
- Humility

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Money/Riches
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

What a Friend We Have in Jesus — Keith and Kristyn Getty
This classic hymn invites direct, honest prayer with the Savior who carries our burdens.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I must hide my money problems"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must hide my money problems." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What am I hiding?
- ☐ What has hiding cost me?
- ☐ Who is a safe person I could tell?
- ☐ What am I afraid will happen?
- ☐ What would I say to a friend in my place?
- ☐ What is one honest step this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I do not have to carry this alone.
- ☐ Wise counsel helps plans succeed.
- ☐ Safe people can carry part of the weight.
- ☐ Honesty is not the same as telling everyone.
- ☐ I can choose who to tell and when.
- ☐ God provides help through people.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Proverbs 15:22**
  "Plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed."
- ☐ **Galatians 6:2**
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."
- ☐ **Ecclesiastes 4:9–10**
  "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!"

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] What I shared: Each week, write down one honest step you took about money, who you told, and how it felt afterward.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 15:22 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Plans succeed with wise counsel, so I can choose a safe person and tell the truth.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Help" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Choose one safe person. Pick someone trustworthy, discreet, and kind, such as a spouse, pastor, counselor, or friend.
- [ ] Write what you want to say. Draft two or three sentences that tell the truth simply.
- [ ] Have the conversation. Share it, ask for support or ideas, and notice how they respond.
- [ ] Seek practical help. Contact a nonprofit credit counselor, financial advisor, or church benevolence team if you need practical guidance.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie “I must hide my money problems”: _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	An honest step
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must hide my money problems.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You see what I have been hiding. Give me courage to be honest, and lead me to wise, safe people. Take the shame out of asking for help and let me not carry this alone. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #13 · DEBT AND SHAME

"I can never get out of this."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

When bills pile up, interest grows, or one setback follows another, the situation can feel like quicksand. Long stress narrows thinking, and past efforts that failed may make a new plan seem pointless. Some people also grew up around families who always owed, which can make debt seem like a permanent condition.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not hide how heavy troubles can be. David says he waited patiently for the Lord, who lifted him up from the pit of despair and set his feet upon a rock. Lamentations says the Lord's mercies are new every morning. Paul says we are hard pressed but not crushed, perplexed but not in despair. Proverbs says the plans of the diligent lead to profit. These verses do not promise a quick fix. They say that God lifts, that mornings come, and that steady steps matter.

> *"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope"* (Jeremiah 29:11).

Also see

> "I waited patiently for the LORD; He inclined to me and heard my cry. He lifted me up from the pit of despair, out of the miry clay; He set my feet upon a rock, and made my footsteps firm" (Psalm 40:1–2).

> "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!" (Lamentations 3:22–23).

> "Now may the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace as you believe in Him, so that you may overflow with hope by the power of the Holy Spirit" (Romans 15:13).

> "The plans of the diligent bring plenty, as surely as haste leads to poverty" (Proverbs 21:5).

Common self-statements

- Nothing I do will ever make a difference.
- I will be paying this off forever.
- There is no way out.
- I have tried everything.
- This is just my life now.
- It is too late to fix it.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that nothing will ever change.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that if I cannot pay it all off, there is no point.
- Catastrophizing: Seeing the whole mountain instead of the next step.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling stuck and concluding that I am stuck for good.

Challenging questions

- What exactly do I owe, and have I written the numbers down?
- What progress have I made, even if small?

- What is one thing that has improved in the past year?
- Who has gotten out of a hard situation, and how?
- What options have I not yet explored, such as counseling, restructuring, or support?
- What is the next smallest step?

Truth summary

> This season is heavy, but "never" is a prediction, not a fact. God lifts people out of pits, and His mercies are new every morning. I can take one clear step at a time and ask for help along the way.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Hopeless
- Hardship
- Trust
- Plans
- God, All Powerful

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Chain Breaker — Zach Williams
Christ offers rescue and freedom to people who feel trapped by their past.

Greater — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
This classic gospel hymn celebrates Christ's rescue and the hope of life with Him.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can never get out of this"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can never get out of this." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly do I owe?
- ☐ What progress have I made?
- ☐ What one step can I take this week?
- ☐ Who can help me look at options?
- ☐ What has God done for me in hard times before?
- ☐ Where am I predicting "never"?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ "Never" is a feeling, not a fact.
- ☐ God's mercies are new every morning.
- ☐ Small steps add up.
- ☐ I can ask for help to find options.
- ☐ I have survived hard seasons before.
- ☐ God has plans for my good and my hope.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Jeremiah 29:11**
  "For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope."
- ☐ **Psalm 40:1–2**
  "I waited patiently for the LORD; He inclined to me and heard my cry. He lifted me up from the pit of despair, out of the miry clay; He set my feet upon a rock, and made my footsteps firm."
- ☐ **Lamentations 3:22–23**
  "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] One step, one number: Each week, write the amount you owe and one step you took, however small. Watch the page fill up.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Lamentations 3:22–23 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God's mercies are new every morning, so I can take one step today.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Hopeless" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Write down the whole picture. List every debt, balance, and minimum payment. Facing the numbers lowers the fear.
- [ ] Choose the next step. Pick one thing, such as a call, a budget, or a conversation, and do it this week.
- [ ] Seek qualified help. Contact a nonprofit credit counseling agency or a trusted advisor about options.
- [ ] Mark small wins. Put a visible check on the calendar for every step taken.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can never get out of this": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step forward
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can never get out of this.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You lift people out of pits. When I feel stuck, remind me that Your mercies are new each morning. Show me the next step and give me hope that this will not last forever. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #14 · DEBT AND SHAME

“I don't deserve anything nice.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

After debt, many people punish themselves: no vacations, no new clothes, no small pleasures, even when there is room for them. Messages that equated owing money with guilt, a parent who said “we can’t afford joy,” or religious teaching that confused simplicity with suffering can all feed this belief. It can also grow after a mistake that cost the family.

What Scripture teaches

Paul asks how God, who did not spare His own Son but gave Him up for us all, will not also freely give us all things. Every good and perfect gift is from above. The psalmist says the Lord withholds no good thing from those who walk with integrity. Ecclesiastes says that it is a gift of God to enjoy the fruit of our labor. None of this is a call to overspend. It means that wise self-denial and gratitude are different from self-punishment.

> *“He who did not spare His own Son but gave Him up for us all, how will He not also, along with Him, freely give us all things?”* (Romans 8:32).

Also see

> “For the LORD God is a sun and a shield; the LORD gives grace and glory; He withholds no good thing from those who walk with integrity” (Psalm 84:11).

> “Every good and perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of the heavenly lights, with whom there is no change or shifting shadow” (James 1:17).

> “Instruct those who are rich in the present age not to be conceited and not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth, but in God, who richly provides all things for us to enjoy” (1 Timothy 6:17).

> “And also that every man should eat and drink and find satisfaction in all his labor—this is the gift of God” (Ecclesiastes 3:13).

Common self-statements

- After what I did, I do not get nice things.
- I should suffer until the debt is paid.
- Enjoying anything would be selfish.
- My family should do without because of me.
- I have to earn the right to be happy.
- Small pleasures are a waste.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I must deprive myself.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that I deserve punishment.
- Magnification: Making one mistake bigger than it is.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I must either spend freely or have no joy at all.

Challenging questions

- Is my self-denial a wise plan or a punishment?

- What would I want for a friend in my situation?
- What does God's gift of His Son say about what He wants to give me?
- What small, inexpensive joys could I accept without guilt?
- Who is helped by my suffering?
- What is the difference between being careful and being cruel to myself?

Truth summary

> Wisdom with money is good. Self-punishment is not. God gives good gifts, and I can receive small joys with thanks while still keeping a sensible budget. I do not have to earn the right to be cared for.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Gifts, Physical/Material
- Thankful
- Love, By God
- Grace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin
God's fatherly love is deeper than human approval or achievement.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I don't deserve anything nice"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I don't deserve anything nice." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Where am I punishing myself?
- ☐ What would I want for a friend?
- ☐ What small joy could I accept this week?
- ☐ What does God's gift of His Son say about me?
- ☐ How is a budget different from punishment?
- ☐ What good gift can I thank God for today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Wise limits are different from self-punishment.
- ☐ God gives good gifts.
- ☐ I can enjoy simple things with thanks.
- ☐ My suffering does not pay the debt.
- ☐ I am worth caring for.
- ☐ Gratitude and budgeting can live together.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 8:32
  "He who did not spare His own Son but gave Him up for us all, how will He not also, along with Him, freely give us all things?"
- ☐ Psalm 84:11
  "For the LORD God is a sun and a shield; the LORD gives grace and glory; He withholds no good thing from those who walk with integrity."
- ☐ James 1:17
  "Every good and perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of the heavenly lights, with whom there is no change or shifting shadow."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] A gift I received: Each day, write down one small good thing you accepted with thanks and note whether guilt showed up.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Romans 8:32 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God gave His Son for me, so I can receive small gifts with thanks.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Thankful" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Plan one small, free or low-cost joy. A walk, a call with a friend, a favorite meal at home. Put it on the calendar.
- [ ] Separate budget from punishment. Write what your budget actually requires, and notice any extra rules you added.
- [ ] Practice receiving. When someone offers a kindness, say "thank you" without explaining or refusing.
- [ ] Thank God for one gift each day. Name it aloud.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I don't deserve anything nice": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A gift I received
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I don't deserve anything nice.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You gave Your Son for me, and You are a giver of good gifts. Heal the place in me that says I do not deserve any good. Teach me to be wise and thankful, and to receive Your care. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #15 · DEBT AND SHAME

"Talking about money is shameful."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

In many families, money was never discussed, or it was discussed only in anger. Phrases like "Don't ask what people earn" or "That is none of your business" can grow into the belief that any talk about money is improper. For some, church or culture added the idea that money is spiritually unclean. The result is people who cannot ask questions, plan with a spouse, or seek help.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture speaks about money openly. Jesus talked about it often, and Proverbs urges us to know the state of our flocks and pay close attention to our herds. Jesus said that anyone who wants to build a tower should first sit down and count the cost. Proverbs says that the wise listen to counsel. Honest conversation about money is not shameful; it is part of stewardship, love, and wisdom, and the psalmist says that those who look to the Lord are radiant with joy and their faces will never be ashamed.

> *"Which of you, wishing to build a tower, does not first sit down and count the cost to see if he has the resources to complete it?"* (Luke 14:28).

Also see

> "Be sure to know the state of your flocks, and pay close attention to your herds" (Proverbs 27:23).
>
> "The way of a fool is right in his own eyes, but a wise man listens to counsel" (Proverbs 12:15).
>
> "For lack of guidance, a nation falls, but with many counselors comes deliverance" (Proverbs 11:14).
>
> "Those who look to Him are radiant with joy; their faces shall never be ashamed" (Psalm 34:5).

Common self-statements

- Money is not something decent people talk about.
- Asking about money is rude.
- If I bring it up, I will look greedy.
- My spouse and I should not argue about money, so we do not talk.
- I would rather not know.
- It is not spiritual to care about money.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Believing I should never discuss money.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling uncomfortable and concluding that it is wrong.
- Avoidance: Staying away from the topic so I do not have to feel the discomfort.
- Mind reading: Assuming others would think badly of me for asking.

Challenging questions

- What did I learn about discussing money growing up?
- What has my silence cost me or my family?

- What would it look like to talk about money kindly and clearly?
- What does Jesus say about counting the cost?
- Who could I practice with first?
- What question about money have I been afraid to ask?

Truth summary

> Talking about money honestly is a form of wisdom and love. I can learn to speak clearly and kindly, ask questions, and plan together with others. Shame is not required, and God's people are not covered with shame.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Money
- Wisdom
- Communication
- Guidance
- Plans

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Communication
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Even If — MercyMe
Trust in God need not depend on receiving the particular miracle we want.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Talking about money is shameful"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Talking about money is shameful." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did I learn about money talk growing up?
- ☐ What has silence cost me?
- ☐ What question have I been afraid to ask?
- ☐ Who could I talk with first?
- ☐ What would a calm money conversation sound like?
- ☐ What does Jesus say about counting the cost?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Talking about money is part of wise stewardship.
- ☐ Counting the cost is biblical.
- ☐ Silence is not the same as peace.
- ☐ I can speak about money kindly and clearly.
- ☐ Questions are not rude.
- ☐ I do not have to feel shame to be careful.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Luke 14:28**
  "Which of you, wishing to build a tower, does not first sit down and count the cost to see if he has the resources to complete it?"
- ☐ **Proverbs 27:23**
  "Be sure to know the state of your flocks, and pay close attention to your herds."
- ☐ **Psalm 34:5**
  "Those who look to Him are radiant with joy; their faces shall never be ashamed."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

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  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
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  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] A money conversation: Each week, note one conversation about money, with whom, and how it went.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Luke 14:28 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Counting the cost is wise, so I can talk about money without shame.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Wisdom" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

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- [ ] Write down one question. What do you most want to understand about your finances?
- [ ] Schedule a calm talk. If you have a spouse or family member, set a time with no distractions and an agreed ending time.
- [ ] Use simple words. Practice a sentence such as, "I would like us to look at our budget together so we can plan."
- [ ] Ask a professional. If needed, meet with a nonprofit counselor or advisor and bring your questions.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Talking about money is shameful": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A money conversation
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My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

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Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Talking about money is shameful.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You are not ashamed of me, and You care about every part of my life, including money. Free me from shame about this subject. Give me words to speak kindly and clearly, and wisdom to plan well. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.